

SENATE RESOLUTION 329

By Akbari

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend the Alpha Beta Chapter of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Inc., on the celebration of the chapter's 100th anniversary.

WHEREAS, it is our pleasure to recognize the Alpha Beta Chapter of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Inc., on the 100th anniversary of its founding; and

WHEREAS, the Alpha Beta Chapter of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Inc., was founded on January 13, 1913; for a full century, this chapter has stood as a pillar of service, scholarship, social action, and sisterhood, rising with the potential to break barriers, challenge societal norms, and redefine success in unimaginable ways; and

WHEREAS, the Alpha Beta Chapter was the first Greek-letter organization permitted on the campus of Fisk University and the first chapter of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Inc., established in this State; and

WHEREAS, more than a decade after the founding of the Alpha Beta Chapter, Fisk University President Fayette Avery McKenzie prohibited most extracurricular student activities, including Black Greek-letter organizations; and

WHEREAS, during the spring of 1925, student-led protests against autocratic leadership and repressive policies, including magazine censorship, a dating prohibition, and restricted conversations between male and female students, successfully forced the president's resignation and ultimately paved the way for the founding of Black Greek-letter organizations at Fisk University; and

WHEREAS, led by Lillian Alexander, conversations with National Headquarters and the Grand Chapter secured permission from Fisk University officials to establish a Delta Sigma Theta collegiate chapter; and

WHEREAS, the Alpha Beta Chapter of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Inc., was officially chartered on March 13, 1926, at Fisk University under the leadership of charter members Hallie Walton Smith, Eloise Lowe Clark, Alyce McCarroll, Jeanne Osby Goodwin, and Anna Jewel Redd, who remained part of the membership intake process for more than a semester; and

WHEREAS, at that time, Dorothy Pelham Beckley was the sorority's national president, and Anna R. Johnson Julian served as regional director; and

WHEREAS, the Delta Sigma Theta Sorority held its eleventh national convention in Nashville in December 1931, cohosted by the members of the Alpha Beta Chapter; and

WHEREAS, the Alpha Beta Chapter has distinguished itself as a public service organization devoted to the highest tenets of community service; its members have hosted study sessions to assist Fisk University students, cohosted a sexual health fair in partnership with Music City PrEP Clinic and Nashville CARES, provided free STI testing and materials for students, and established a scholarship fund to pay in full the balances of the chapter's members; and

WHEREAS, notable sorors of the Alpha Beta Chapter include Minerva Hatcher Johnson Hawkins, 1927 Alpha Beta initiate and President of Pi Sigma, who served as Southern Regional Director from 1941 to 1946 and was renowned throughout the Nashville community as a pioneer in education; Hortense Golden Canady, 1944 Alpha Beta initiate, who served as national (international) president from 1983 to 1988, and whose daughter, Alexa Canady, became the first African-American woman neurosurgeon; Julia Agnes Washington Bond, 1927 initiate of Alpha Beta, who served as librarian and was the mother of Civil Rights activist Julian Bond; Katherine Crosby Bowman, 1947 graduate of Fisk University, who wrote *Across the River*; Kym Whitley, 1983 Alpha Beta initiate and renowned actress, comedian, and activist; Josie Robinson Johnson; Carolyn Jordan Booker; and Ramona Hoage Edelin, Ph.D.; and

WHEREAS, additionally, Helen E. Woods was initiated through the Alpha Beta Chapter and served as Southern Regional Director from 1936 to 1942, and Yolanda R. Moore served as Southern Regional Representative from 2003 to 2005; and

WHEREAS, current chapter members who are successfully continuing the rich legacy of the Alpha Beta chapter include Chapter President Dania Rutherford; First Vice President Karli Lusain; Second Vice President Carline Boston; Treasurer Tamiyah Dubose; Corresponding Secretary Chloe Nimaga; Recording Secretary Lauryn Fowler; Financial Secretary Jayla Simmons; Internal Auditor Aries Fitzgerald; and Historian Delaney Farver; and

WHEREAS, for 100 years, Alpha Beta members have championed educational advancement, civic engagements, cultural awareness, and leadership development, exemplifying the ideals set forth by its twenty-two founding members; Alpha Beta's story is one of purpose, pride, and progress, and the next century begins with the same unwavering commitment to creating a meaningful difference; and

WHEREAS, as the oldest collegiate chapter in the southern region, Alpha Beta was chartered by five visionary collegiate women who were wholly committed to uplifting their campus and community and has grown to be a legacy-bearing chapter rooted in excellence and impact; and

WHEREAS, the Alpha Beta Chapter of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Inc., continues to stand as a pillar of success, and it is fitting that the members of this legislative body honor the members on the chapter's centennial celebration; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, that we hereby honor and commend the members, past and present, of the Alpha Beta Chapter of Delta Sigma Theta Sorority, Inc., on the celebration of the chapter's 100th anniversary and extend our best wishes for every continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy.